propaganda campaign has become a major element of its foreign policy. The world is just beginning to wake up to the scope of Beijing's propaganda activities. Its influence operations span the globe, ranging from covert attempts to influence policy makers and opinion leaders to overt actions designed to overwhelm opposition to China's policies. An August 2018 report by the US-China Economic and Security Review Commission documented the overseas propaganda and influence activities of the CCP, specifically the role played by the party's United Front Work Department (UFWD).

The UFWD was created in 1939 by Mao Zedong to combat both the Japanese and the Nationalist government, while pretending to work with the Nationalists. This approach has marked United Front activities throughout the decades. The United Front's goal, noted the US-China Commission report, is "to co-opt and neutralize sources of potential opposition to the policies and authority" of the CCP.[56] Under Xi Jinping, the UFWD has been rejuvenated and its influence increased. A "leading small group"—a key institutional mechanism for coordinating policy on important issues—was established in 2015 for United Front work, drawing in top officials and over two dozen government agencies. The UFWD also appears to have "growing links" with China's security service, and has been given "unified management" over religious groups and overseas Chinese affairs.[57]

Much United Front and other overseas government work is focused on finding sympathetic allies in countries where Beijing hopes to increase its influence. Official groups such as the Chinese People's Association for Friendship with Foreign Countries and the China Overseas Friendship Association are used to reach out to foreign government officials, business leaders, academics, and media leaders. These are paired with numerous diplomatic initiatives such as the Boao Forum for Asia, the Forum on China-Africa Cooperation, and the Shanghai Cooperation Organization. Billions of dollars in aid have gone to local elites throughout Eurasia and the Pacific, as well as Africa and Latin America, directly or indirectly, causing them to espouse political support for China in international forums.[58]